PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Jeep Wrangler TJ

1997–2006 · TJ

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Frame rust, especially the rear control-arm mounts**
  Quadratec says plainly that TJ frames still rust. Check the rails inside and out, the skid-plate areas and the rear lower control-arm brackets, where it warns rust can become severe enough to cause structural failure. Rick Rotondo adds the transfer-case crossmember and central body mounts to the list.

- [ ] **Floors and the early cowl leak**
  Look under the carpet, especially in the front footwells. Off Road Xtreme notes that the cowl vent on early TJs leaks water into the cab, rusting the floor and growing mold in the carpet. Jeep revised the design later.

- [ ] **Ask about the OPDA on 2005–06 4.0s**
  Listen for the 'laughing monkey' noise at idle. With no record of a replacement, Quadratec recommends replacing the oil pump drive assembly proactively, because a failure can damage the engine.

- [ ] **Drive it at 30–50 mph**
  Off Road Xtreme says that's the speed range to check for death wobble, usually caused by a loose lower track-bar bolt. Check the track bar, ball joints, tie-rod ends, stabilizer and control-arm bushings for wear, and look for bent steering linkage.

- [ ] **Oil leaks are normal; puddles aren't**
  The 4.0 commonly leaks from the rear main seal, oil pan gasket, valve cover gasket and oil-filter adapter. Drivingline adds pinion and transfer-case output seals. Price in the rear main seal if the bellhousing is wet.

- [ ] **Radiator end tanks**
  The factory radiator has plastic end tanks crimped to an aluminum core, and Quadratec says many start leaking at the upper seams around 100,000 miles. Look for green crust, coolant smell and small leaks. Off Road Xtreme recommends an all-aluminum radiator, partly because the 4.0 runs warm.

- [ ] **Which rear axle and which gearbox?**
  Find the axle tag: a Dana 44 rear beats the Dana 35 if you plan bigger tires. Drivingline says the AX-15 has known synchro issues, the NV3550 is stronger, and the 32RH automatic is durable but revs high on the highway.

- [ ] **Transfer case won't go into 4-Low?**
  Quadratec says to check the shift linkage first, because it pops out of worn plastic bushings. It's a cheap fix, but it's a good haggling point.

YEARS TO KNOW

1997–99	BEWARE	Early-TJ teething: SlashGear notes seven recalls for 1997 and early engine-computer, fuel-system and brake bugs; Driving Line says cracked 4.0 exhaust manifolds are most

common on 1997–2000 trucks; Off Road Xtreme says the early cowl vent leaks water onto the floors, a design Jeep revised on later TJs

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Airbag control module software**
  1997 · NHTSA 96V060000
- ☐ **Inadvertent airbag deployment at shut-off**
  1997 · NHTSA 97V080000
- ☐ **Driver airbag clockspring**
  1997 · NHTSA 98V046000
- ☐ **Front seat-belt turning loops**
  1998 · NHTSA 98V048000
- ☐ **Brake booster vacuum diaphragm**
  1998 · NHTSA 98V023000
- ☐ **Instrument-panel ground screws**
  1999 · NHTSA 99V117000
- ☐ **Ignition switch water intrusion**
  2001–2002 · NHTSA 02V075000
- ☐ **4.0 L manifold debris at cylinder 3**
  2000–2002 · NHTSA 02V104000
- ☐ **42RLE park pawl anchor shaft**
  2005–2006 · NHTSA 05V460000
- ☐ **Six-speed clutch master cylinder rod**
  2006 · NHTSA 06V147000

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **VIN trim code**
  All TJ VINs start 1J4FA. The 6th character marks the trim: 2 SE, 3 X, 4 Sport, 5 Sahara, 6 Rubicon. In BaT-listed VINs we checked, the 7th was 9 on short-wheelbase trucks and 4 on the Unlimited (a Rubicon reads 1J4FA69…, an Unlimited Rubicon 1J4FA64…), but NHTSA's decoder doesn't separate the two, so confirm by wheelbase.
- ☐ **VIN engine code**
  The 8th character is the engine: S is the 4.0 L six, P the 2.5 L four and 1 the 2.4 L four (NHTSA decoder: 1J4FA29P… is a 2.5 L SE, 1J4FA291… a 2.4 L SE).
- ☐ **Real Rubicon hardware**
  Front and rear Dana 44s with air-actuated lockers and dash switches, the Rock-Trac NV241OR transfer case with a 4:1 low range, diamond-plate rocker guards and 16-inch alloys on LT245/75R16 tires.
- ☐ **Rear axle**
  Sport, SE and X trucks normally have the weaker Dana 35. A Dana 44 rear was optional on Sport and Sahara, sometimes with a Trac-Lok limited slip. The axle tag and cover shape tell you which one you have.
- ☐ **Transmission by year**
  Manual 4.0 trucks used the AX-15 (1997–99), the NV3550 (2000–04) and the NSG370 six-speed (2005–06). Automatics are the 32RH 3-speed (1997–2002) and the 42RLE 4-speed (2003–06).
- ☐ **Special editions**
  The 2003 Tomb Raider Rubicon has a serial-numbered badge, red seat belts and Bright Silver paint. The 2001 60th Anniversary came only in black or Silverstone.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/jeep/tj/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks